

PHOTOGRAPH BY HEMANT CHAWLA, location courtesy: Hotel Shangri-La, New Delhi



But insomnia is just the tip of the iceberg. More alarmingly, Sleep-Disordered Breathing (SDB) and Obstructive Sleep Apnea (OSA)—a condition in which people stop breathing frequently, during nights, often for 10 seconds or longer—is on the rise. Sample this: In 2000, Dr Zarir Udawadia of P.D. Hinduja Hospital, Mumbai, found that out of 700 patients 8 per cent were suffering from OSA. "This is the highest in the world. About 5 per cent in the US and Europe suffer from this disorder," he says. In yet another study, conducted in 2005, by Dr Rajendra Prasad and his team at the King George's Medical University in Lucknow, it was concluded that 60 per cent of the loud snorers were at a high risk of OSA.

Blame it all on modern lifestyle and work. In the past, people would flood out of office gates and leave work behind as soon as the clock struck five. "People now tend to work for long hours, often through the night, which means they rarely get to wind down," says Mohan Varghese, professor of psychiatry at the National Institute of Mental Health and Neurosciences, Bangalore. With mobile phones, laptops and Blackberries, work follows everywhere—they erode the separation between work and home and that makes it

Do we need sleep?

Is it to refresh the body?

Not really. Muscles don't need sleep, just periods of relaxation. The rest of the body chugs along seemingly unaware of whether the brain is asleep or awake.

Is it to refresh the mind?

That's closer to the mark. For the brain to strengthen its neural networks that enable us to learn new tricks and remember old ones, sleeping is vital, say experts.

It aids in memory consolidation and organ function:

Researchers say, sleep is the missing link when it comes to overall health, safety and productivity.

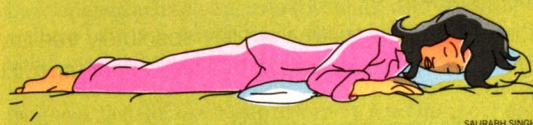
How to sleep well?

Pillow Talk:

- Your pillow should keep your head at body level.
- Place a small pillow between your knees. (see below)



- Use a firm mattress to avoid backache.
- Put a small pillow under your waist if you sleep lying on your stomach. (see below)



SAURABH SINGH

4 sleep factors that affect performance

Homeostatic Drive: It's the drive for sleep. At its peak, thousands of neurons in the brain's 'sleep switch' ignite. Sleep seizes the brain like a pilot grabbing controls. Listen to it and get to bed.

Total Sleep: Eight hours at night will keep you alert. Less than that for several days, will build up sleep deficit and make it difficult for the brain to function. So get that sleep.

Circadian Phase: Neurons send out strongest drive for sleep just before waking, and that for waking just before going to bed. No one knows why. Regular sleep schedule keeps it under control.

Sleep Inertia: That feeling of grogginess when you first wake up because the brain needs time to 'warm up', like a car engine. So wake up calmly.